

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS SIGHT RECORD FORM

7-0(A)

Red 5/5/00 wpl

Species: Glossy Ibis Plegadis falcinellus

Date of Observation: April 25, 2000

Number of birds seen: One Sex: Unknown Plumage: Adult breeding

Exact location: Between Eagle River and I-70, east of Squaw Creek Waste Water Treatment Plant and west of Lake Creek Village townhomes

County: Eagle Nearest town: Edwards Elevation: 7120 feet (2170 meters)

Length of observation: One half hour Times: 10:35 to 11:05 a.m.

Other observers who saw bird with me: None

Other observers who independently saw bird: John Amoroso and Brad Benter. John called me the evening of April 24 to tell about the bird; you should be getting or have gotten a report from them.

Light conditions: Bright sun coming from the side part of the time and from behind me part of the time.

Optical equipment used: Bushnell 50 mm spotting 'scope on a tripod at the best sun angle, Kowa TSN-2 'scope on a window mount at the poor angles.

Distance from the bird: 200 feet down to perhaps 75 feet at the closest

No photographs - anyway, none by me

Habitat: Shallow, marshy ponds surrounded by tall grass; clumps of cattails.

Behavior: Feeding by probing the mud with its long bill. Flew around once or twice, fairly low, gliding a lot, neck and legs extended. Tended to remain apart from the White-faced Ibises that were there.

Description: Moderately large wading bird with long legs, long neck, and long downward-curved bill. Appears black in flight or in less than very good light. In full sun neck and body are purplish brown with green areas on wings and tail. Face dark gray or black outlined by a light blue line from the top of one eye across the top of the bill to the other eye; another blue line from the bottom of the eye to the chin. Blue line does not go around the eye. Legs are grayish with red at the joint.

Voice: One ibis gave a nondescript croak as it took off, but I think it wasn't the Glossy Ibis. Otherwise they made little noise.

Similar species: The White-faced Ibis is almost identical to the Glossy; differences are in the face and legs. The White-faced Ibis has red bare facial skin between the eye and the bill where the Glossy is almost black. Around the bare face skin the White-faced has a white line, clean, bright white in some individuals but faint and pinkish in others. The white line goes around behind the eye. The corresponding line of the Glossy is blue in breeding season and does not extend behind the eye. The legs of the Glossy Ibis are gray except at the joint, which is red; the legs of the White-faced are all red. There is also a difference in the bill color when the birds are not probing in the mud, but these birds' bills were muddy.

Curlews are also wading birds with long decurved bills and might be confused with ibis if seen only in silhouette. Curlews all have brown backs with mottled or scaly patterns and lighter colored underparts. The subject bird, being dark underneath, could not have been a curlew. Also the purplish brown color of its plumage has an iridescent quality lacking in curlews and no patterning.

Prior experience: This is only the second Glossy Ibis I've ever seen, the other having been a winter-plumage bird in Florida. I am, however, quite familiar with the White-faced Ibis, which appear here in the Eagle Valley almost every spring, usually in flocks of 20 to 100 birds. Having had this opportunity to compare the two species, I would suggest to field guide authors that they place more emphasis on the red facial skin of the White-faced Ibis, as that mark works for those birds with a weak white border around it.

Books used in the identification: The National Geographic Society Field Guide to the Birds of North America

This report was made from memory, with a little help from notes made shortly after the sighting.

Date of written report: April 29, 2000

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